Country Profile: Georgia

- Number of groups in country: 6
- Plurality religion: Georgian Orthodox
- Official language: Georgian (throughout the country); Abkhazian (in the Autonomous Republic of Abkhazia)
- Official religion: None
- Core group: Georgians

Historical Background

On May 26, 1918, amid the turmoil of World War I and the collapse of the Russian Empire, Georgia declared its independence and established the Democratic Republic of Georgia. However, this period of independence was short-lived. In 1921, the Soviet Army invaded Georgia, leading to the country's incorporation into the Soviet Union. Georgia was initially incorporated into the Transcaucasian SFSR and later, in 1936, reconstituted as the Georgian SSR.[1]

Following the dissolution of the Soviet Union, Georgia declared independence on April 9, 1991. The early years of sovereignty were marred by civil strife and conflicts, particularly in the regions of Abkhazia and South Ossetia (Tskhinvali Region). Georgia lost de facto control over the regions of Abkhazia and South Ossetia (Tskhinvali Region), which together make up about 20% of its territory, following the Georgian-Ossetian conflict in 1991–1992 and the Abkhaz-Georgian conflict in 1992–1993. These regions later declared independence after the Five Day War in August 2008.[2]

Groups

- **Georgians** are a core ethnic group in Georgia, representing 86.8% of the total population according to the latest census.[3] The majority of Georgians speak the Georgian language[4] and adhere to the Georgian Orthodox Church.[5]

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[1] Kazemzadeh, 1951.
[2] UCDP, 2024.
[3] National Statistics Office of Georgia, 2014.
[4] Ethnologue, 2024.
[5] EPR-ED, 2021.

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- **Azeris** in Georgia trace their origins back to the 16th century, when Qizilbash tribes began migrating and settling in the southern regions of the country, leading to the establishment of the Azerbaijani community by the early 17th century.[6] Azeris are compactly settled in the south-east region of Kvemo Kartli, bordering on Azerbaijan, and represent around 6.3% of the population.[7] They predominantly speak the North Azerbaijani language and adhere to Twelver Shiism. In the early 1990s, several Azeri associations, including the Geyret popular movement, emerged in Georgia, advocating for cultural autonomy and increased representation in local government as part of a broader self-determination movement.[8]
- **Armenians** initially settled in Tbilisi during the 12th and 13th centuries, following the liberation of the Caucasus from the Seljuk Turks by Georgian and Armenian forces.[9] Today, they are the third largest ethnic group in Georgia, making up about 4.5% of the population, a figure that has declined due to emigration to Armenia after the collapse of the USSR.[10] While most Armenians in Georgia speak Western Armenian, Russian is also commonly used for communication.[11] Although Armenians share Eastern Orthodox Christian roots with Georgians, they predominantly belong to the Armenian Apostolic Church.[12] The Armenian population is primarily concentrated in the Javakheti region in southwestern Georgia, near the Armenian border. In this region, Armenian nationalist movements have pushed for greater territorial autonomy and even secession.[13]
- **South Ossetians** speak the Ossetic language, are fluent in Russian, and are concentrated mainly in the Tskhinvali Region (South Ossetia) and its adjacent region, Shida Kartli.[14] South Ossetians share a common ethnic origin with North Ossetians, who now reside in the Republic of North Ossetia in Russia. The administrative division between these two groups began in the 16th century.[15]

[6] Брегадзе, 1976.
[7] Minority Rights, 2018; National Statistics Office of Georgia, 2014.
[8] Minority Rights, 2018; Sambanis, Germann, and Schädel, 2018.
[9] De Waal, 2018.
[10] National Statistics Office of Georgia, 2014.
[11] Ethnologue, 2024.
[12] EPR-ED, 2021.
[13] Minority Rights, 2018.
[14] DFWatch, 2012.
[15] ХАДИКОВА, 2012.

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Modern censuses in Georgia do not distinguish between South and North Ossetians, categorizing them collectively as Ossetians. Since 1988, South Ossetians have been involved in a self-determination movement, which led to the Georgian-South Ossetian conflict, further complicated by the involvement of the Russian Federation and resulting in the secession of South Ossetia from Georgia.[16] These factors make it challenging to accurately estimate the demographic size of this group. According to the 1989 census, Ossetians comprised about 3% of Georgia's population.[17] However, the 2014 census shows that only 14,300 Ossetians, or 0.4%, live in Georgian-controlled territories, while the South Ossetian census estimates around 48,000 Ossetians reside in the self-declared Republic of South Ossetia.[18] The majority of Ossetians adhere to Orthodox Christianity, and parts of the group have historically also practiced some pagan traditions.

- **Abkhazians** speak the Abkhazian language; however, Russian is also increasingly used as a language of communication and bureaucracy.[19] For group members, Eastern Orthodox Christianity is the main religion, but Muslim and animist traditions have been salient in different historical periods.[20] Abkhazians are predominantly concentrated in the Georgian Autonomous Republic of Abkhazia and have been involved in a secessionist movement focused on this territory since 1988, leading to the Georgian-Abkhaz conflict of 1992-1993.[21] Following the war, Georgia lost de facto control over the territory, and the conflict remains frozen. Therefore, demographic information about Abkhazians is limited. The 1989 census recorded approximately 96,000 Abkhazians, accounting for 1.8% of Georgia's total population.[22] In contrast, the 2014 census counted fewer than 1,000 Abkhazians residing in government-controlled areas.[23] Meanwhile, the 2011 census

[16] Minority Rights, 2018.
[17] Demoscop, 2007.
[18] National Statistics Office of Georgia, 2014; Итоги всеобщей переписи населения Республики Южная Осетия, 2016.
[19] Moseley, 2010.
[20] Minority Rights, 2018.
[21] UCDP, 2024; Sambanis, Germann, and Schädel, 2018.
[22] Demoscop, 2007.
[23] National Statistics Office of Georgia, 2014.

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conducted in the self-proclaimed Abkhazian republic estimated around 122,000 Abkhazians living in the region.[24]

- **Adzhars** speak Adzhar, which is a dialect of the Georgian language.[25] The majority of the group members are Georgian Orthodox;[26] however, historically, Sunni Islam has also been a common denomination. Many Adzhars were converted to Islam in the 16th and 17th centuries, when the Ottomans ruled over southwestern Georgian territories.[27] Adzhars are predominantly found in the Autonomous Republic of Adjara and make up around 8.9% of the Georgian population, according to estimates of the total population of the Autonomous Republic of Adjaria.[28] Since 1988, they have been participating in a self-determination movement demanding stronger political, economic, and cultural rights in order to preserve their mixed religious identities.[29]

State Profile

Official Language

The official language of Georgia is Georgian, according to the 1995 Constitution. Georgian is a Kartvelian language and is spoken by the majority of the population. The language holds a significant place in Georgia's national identity and is used in government, education, media, and daily communication. *De jure*, Abkhaz is also recognized as an official language alongside Georgian in the Autonomous Republic of Abkhazia.[30]

Official Religion

Georgia does not have an official state religion; however, the predominant religion is Georgian Orthodox Christianity. The Georgian Orthodox Church is highly influential and has a special constitutional status, reflecting its significant role in the cultural and historical identity of the country.

[24] Наша Абхазия, 2012.
[25] Ethnologue, 2024.
[26] National Statistics Office of Georgia, 2014.
[27] Bennigsen, Wimbush, and Enders, 1986, 207.
[28] National Statistics Office of Georgia, 2014.
[29] Sambanis, Germann, and Schädel, 2018; Minority Rights, 2018.
[30] Constitution of Georgia, 1995.

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Education Policies

The education system in Georgia includes public as well as **private schools**, which consist of primary education (grades 1–6), basic education (grades 7–9), and secondary education (grades 10–12). The school system in Georgia **has not been segregated** on the basis of sex, race, religion, or ethnicity.

Georgia has introduced **affirmative action** for ethnic minorities to support their access to higher education. Between 2010 and 2020, the "4+1" program was introduced to allow Armenian, Azeri, South Ossetian, and Abkhaz students to undertake the entry examination in their own languages. Students who pass the threshold spend their first year studying Georgian before proceeding to higher education at Georgian state universities for four years of undergraduate studies. Given that Adzhars speak a dialect of the Georgian language and do not encounter challenges in accessing education in Georgian, the state has not implemented any affirmative action measures specifically for this group.[31]

Language Education Policies

According to the Law on General Education, the language of instruction in Georgia is Georgian, and in the Autonomous Republic of Abkhazia, Abkhazian; however, students whose mother tongue is neither of these languages can receive education in their own minority language. The language of instruction has to be approved by the Ministry of Education of Georgia on an individual basis.[32]

In the regions inhabited by Armenians and Azeris, Azeri and Armenian languages can be used as languages of instruction. Additionally, Russian was a mandatory foreign language in Georgia before 2011 in both primary and secondary schools; although, starting in 2011, it became an optional class.[33] In 2020, there were 11 Russian schools and 47 Russian sectors (Georgian schools with a Russian department) in Georgia.[34]

[31] Office of the State Minister of Georgia for Reconciliation and Civil Equality, 2020.
[32] Law on General Education, 2005, 8.
[33] Ministry of Education, Science and Youth of Georgia, 2021.
[34] საქართველოში 58 რუსულენოვანი სკოლა და სექტორია.

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Private schools in Georgia can individually liaise with the Ministry of Education to seek approval for using foreign languages for instruction. Any foreign language can be taught if the school has appropriate resources, including the teaching staff.[35]

Religious Education Policies

From 1988 to 1991, "History of Christianity" was a mandatory class in schools, becoming optional in 1991. Between 1991 and 1997, other religious denominations were not included in the curriculum. According to the 1997 Law on General Education, the Ministry of Education and Science of Georgia had to consult with the Georgian Orthodox Church to define the education curriculum in the country.[36]

When the new 2005 Law on General Education came into effect, teaching the history of religion was no longer mandatory. Today, History of Religions is part of Geography, History, and Civic Education classes; nevertheless, debates have emerged about the reintroduction of "Religion" as a separate optional class. According to the Law on General Education, students can participate in religious rituals and study at school outside regular teaching hours, provided that these activities serve educational purposes.[37] According to the same law, private schools can provide religious instruction.[38]

Demographic Engineering and Violence

State-Based Violence

The dissolution of the Soviet Union gave rise to an armed conflict over the region of South Ossetia, which strove for independence from the newly independent Georgia. After 1992, the conflict remained frozen for a long time, with sporadic violence and no political solution within reach. The conflict escalated again in 2008, when the Russian Army became involved in the war. According to the Uppsala Conflict Data, this conflict has resulted in 782 casualties, but the number of civilian losses is low and does not meet the NBP dataset threshold for state-based violence.[39]

The self-proclaimed Republic of Abkhazia sought independence from Georgia. The War in Abkhazia, fought between 1992 and 1993, involved primarily Georgian government

[35] Ministry of Education, Science and Youth of Georgia, 2021.
[36] Dolidze, 2022.
[37] Law on General Education, 2005.
[38] Law on General Education, 2005.
[39] UCDP, 2024.

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forces against Abkhaz separatists, Russian government troops, and North Caucasian militants. Following 1993, the conflict entered a prolonged frozen state, characterized by sporadic violence and minimal progress in peace negotiations. However, since the conflict was not primarily targeted at civilians and the number of civilian casualties remains relatively low, it does not meet the threshold of violence required for inclusion in the NBP dataset.[40]

There was a political crisis between the autonomous republic of Adzharia and the Georgian central government; however, the crisis did not result in casualties or violence that affected civilians.

Constitutions and Laws

There are three Constitutions under consideration in the NBP dataset, respectively adopted in 1978, 1992, and 1995. The 1978 Constitution of the Soviet Socialist Republic of Georgia was partially used in the early period of independence. This Constitution only refers to the Soviet People without individual mention of ethnic groups; however, it recognizes Georgian as an official language of the Georgia SSR while guaranteeing the free use of Russian.[41] In 1992, the 1921 constitution of the first Independent Republic of Georgia was reintroduced to serve as an interim constitution.[42] The 1992 (1921) Constitution does not refer to specific ethnic groups; it recognizes the separation of church and state, and declares Georgian as an official state language. The 1995 Constitution underscores the "centuries-old traditions of the statehood of the Georgian nation and the historical and legal legacy of the Constitution of Georgia of 1921," and it "proclaim[s] this Constitution before God and the nation." This constitution declares Georgian and Abkhaz as official state languages. The 1995 Constitution recognizes the freedom of religion; at the same time it specifically underlines the "outstanding role of the Apostolic Autocephalous Orthodox Church of Georgia in the history of Georgia and its independence from the State." Amendments introduced in 2004, 2010, and 2018 did not alter the provisions related to ethnic groups, respective languages, and religions.[43]

[40] UCDP, 2024.
[41] The Constitution of the Georgian SSR, 1978.
[42] The Constitution of Georgia, 1921.
[43] The Constitution of Georgia, 1995 (rev 2018).

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Citizenship Laws

Citizenship legislation in Georgia was initially governed by the Organic Law on Citizenship of 1993, which was later replaced by the 2014 Law on Citizenship. The Georgian citizenship regime is fundamentally based on the principle of *ius sanguinis*.[44] The possibility of acquiring citizenship through *ius soli* is limited to children of stateless or unknown parents.[45] In terms of naturalization procedures, there are no ethnic- or language-based distinctions affecting how citizenship can be acquired. A "simplified procedure" is available for individuals who qualify through marriage or the repatriation process.[46]

National Anthem(s)

The first Georgian national anthem, titled "Dideba zetsit kurtheuls," commonly known as "Dideba" [Glory] was adopted in 1918 and again in 1991 after Georgia regained independence from the Soviet Union. "Dideba" was initially adopted as the national anthem of the Democratic Republic of Georgia in 1918, following the country's declaration of independence after the fall of the Russian Empire. Following the dissolution of the Soviet Union and Georgia's second declaration of independence in 1991, "Dideba" was reinstated as the national anthem. The anthem was only available in the Georgian language, and the lyrics included explicit references to ancestors, territory, and religion.[47]

The current Georgian national anthem, titled "Tavisupleba" which means "freedom", is a symbol of the country's national identity and pride. The music for "Tavisupleba" was composed by Zacharia Paliashvili, a renowned Georgian composer, and the melody is derived from his operas. The lyrics were written by David Magradze, a prominent Georgian poet. "Tavisupleba" was adopted as the national anthem of Georgia in April 2004, following the Rose Revolution, which marked a significant period of political change and reform in the country. The lyrics of "Tavisupleba" express themes of freedom, national pride, and the beauty of Georgia and include references to ancestors, national territory,

[44] Gugushvili, 2012.
[45] Ibid.
[46] Law on Citizenship of Georgia, 2014.
[47] Former National Anthem of Georgia დიდება "Glory".

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and religion (though not explicitly).[48] The lyrics are available in two official languages: Georgian and Abkhazian.

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